Reading: Pronunciation and Accent Neutralisation

Department of English

GLA University, Mathura

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Pronunciation and Accent Neutralisation

- Pronunciation refers to the way words are spoken, while accent pertains to the way speech sounds (based on region and/or culture) influence language.

Accent Neutralization is the process of reducing or modifying a person's accent to make the speech more universally understandable, typically aligning it with a standard or widely accepted pronunciation. This is often done in professional settings where clear communication is essential, such as in call centers, media, or global business environments.

It does not mean completely eliminating an accent but rather reducing strong regional influences that might cause comprehension issues. The process involves training in pronunciation, stress patterns, intonation, and rhythm to bring the speaker's accent closer to a standard form of a language, such as General American English or Received Pronunciation (RP) in British English.

- Accent Neutralization helps individuals to speak clearly and be understood across different regions.
- Why is Pronunciation Important?

I. Enhances clarity in communication.
II. Reduces misunderstanding in professional and social settings.
III. Helps in better integration in global workplaces.
IV. Proficiency in neutralised accents can increase job opportunities.

Pronunciation

- Pronunciation refers to how we produce the speech sound(s) that we use to make meaning when we speak.
- It includes the particular consonants and vowels of the language (segments) and aspects of speech beyond the level of individual segment, such as- stress, rhythm, pitch and intonation (suprasegmental aspect).
- Phoneme is the smallest unit of speech sound that distinguishes one word from another.
- To overcome articulation challenges one can practice pronouncing word with minimal phonemic difference and tongue twisters.

Accent

- Word accent refers to the way in which a certain part of a word is emphasized (stressed) more than others when speaking.
- Accent is either placed on a certain **syllable** in a word, or on a whole word within a sentence. In English, accented syllables tend to be slightly louder, longer, and higher pitched than the other syllables.
- Accent can be used to change the meaning of a word/sentence or to differentiate the function of a word.
- In phonetic transcriptions, stress is shown with the diacritic [ˈ].
- Locating the accent on correct syllable/word is key to improve pronunciation, comprehension and communication in English.

Syllable

- **Syllable:** A syllable is a basic unit of organization within a sequence of speech sounds, such as within a word, typically defined by linguists as a nucleus (most often a vowel) with optional sounds before or after that nucleus (margins, which are most often consonants). Syllables are often considered the "building blocks" of words. They can influence the rhythm of a language, its prosody, its poetic meter and its stress patterns. Speech can usually be divided up into a whole number of syllables: for example, the word ignite is made of two syllables: ig and nite.
- **Syllabification:** is the separation of a word into syllables. The construction of a syllable may be described in terms of the following formula: [C]+V=Syllable Where C indicates consonants and V stands for a vowel, syllabification is shown by hyphen (-).
- In English words can be:-

I. **Monosyllabic:** God (CVC), Man (CVC), Class (CCVC), Tongue (CVC)

II. **Disyllabic:** Sister (sis-ter), Tiger (ti-ger), Water (wa-ter), Paper (pa-per)

III. **Polysyllabic:** Memory (me-mo-ry), Agriculture (agri-cul-ture), Remember (re-mem-ber)

Common Stress Rules

A. Morphologically Simple Words

Rule 1: Monosyllabic simple word has only one primary stress

One word cannot have two stresses. If we hear two stresses, we hear two words. Two stresses cannot be one word. It is true that there can be a "secondary" stress in some words. But a secondary stress is much smaller than the main [primary] stress, and is only used in long words.

Monosyllabic words will have just one primary stress.

E.g:

➢ Moon / ˈmuːn/

➢ Zoo /ˈzuː/

➢ Tea /ˈtiː/

Cont..

Rule 2 (disyllabic simple word): Stress on first syllable

Word Category	Examples
2-syllable nouns	ˈpre-sent (I have bought a present for you.)[SEP]ˈex-port (The export rate is high in our country.)[SEP]ˈob-ject (The objects are kept in the drawer.)[SEP]ˈper-mit (I asked to see his permit)
2-syllable adjectives	ˈpre-sent (A doctor must be present at the clinic)[SEP]ˈex-port (The government imposed new export duties on certain goods)[SEP]ˈob-ject (The new law made the previously popular product object of criticism[SEP]ˈper-mit (Your work permit will expire soon)

Rule 3(disyllabic simple word): Stress on second syllable

Word Category	Examples
2-syllable verbs	pre-ˈsent (The company will present a new product at trade fair) ex-ˈport (The company plans to export its new technology to Europe. ob-ˈject (Many local people object to the building of the new airport) per-ˈmit (Her parents will not permit her to go to the party)

Cont..

B. Complex Words (containing affixes)

Rule 4:Stress on penultimate syllable (penultimate = second from end)

Word Category	Examples
Words ending in **-ic**	ˈgra-phic /ˈgræf-ɪk/ [Graphic] ge-o-ˈgra-phic /dʒi-əˈgræf-ɪk/ [Geographic] ge-o-ˈlo-gic /dʒiː-ə-ˈlɒ-dʒɪk/ [Geologic]
Words ending in **-sion** and **-tion**	Tel-e-ˈvis-ion /tel-ɪ-ˈvɪʒ-ən/ [Television] rev-e-ˈla-tion /rev-ə-ˈleɪ-ʃən/ [Revelation] ex-am-i-ˈna-tion /ɪg-zæm-ɪˈneɪ-ʃən/ [Examination]

Rule 5: Stress on ante-penultimate syllable (ante-penultimate = third from end)

Word Category	Examples
Words ending in **-cy**, **-ty**, **-phy** and **-gy**	tech-ˈno-lo-gy /tek-ˈnɒl-ə-dʒi/ [Technology] de-ˈmo-cra-cy /dɪ-ˈmɒk-rə-si/ [Democracy] de-pen-da-ˈbi-li-ty /dɪ-pen-də-ˈbɪl-ə-ti/ [Dependability] pho-ˈto-gra-phy /fə-ˈtɒg-rə-fi/ [Photography] ge-ˈo-lo-gy /dʒi-ˈɒl-ə-dʒi/ [Geology]
Words ending in **-al**	ˈcrit-i-cal /ˈkrɪt-ɪ-kəl/ [Critical] ˈdi-gi-tal /ˈdɪdʒ-ɪ-təl/ [Digital] el- ˈec-tri-cal /ɪl-ˈektrɪ-kəl/ [Electrical]

Cont..

C. Compound Words

- According to Peter Roach (2009), in compound words primary stress is found in both the instances; first constituent and second constitute of the compound word. A few rules can be given, although not completely reliable.

Word Category	Example
The most familiar type of compound is the one which combines two nouns and which normally has the stress on the first element.	'typewriter /ˈtaɪp-raɪ-t̬ə˞/ 'car ferry /ˈkɑːr –fer-i/ ˈblack-bird /ˈblæk-bɜːd/ ˈgreen-house /ˈgriːn-haʊs/ 'teacup /ˈtiː-kʌp/
Compounds words often have secondary stress with an adjectival first element and the -ed morpheme at the end.	bad-'tempered /bæd-ˈtempəd/ old-ˈfashioned /əʊld-ˈfæʃənd/ heavy-'handed /hev-iˈhæn-dɪd/

Cont..

Compounds in which the first element is a number in some form also tend to have final stress:	**three-'wheeler /θriː-ˈwiː-lə-/ second-'class /sek-ənd ˈklæs/**
Compounds functioning as adverbs are usually final-stressed:	head'first /hedˈfɜrst/ North-'East /nɔːrθˈiːst/ down'stream /daʊnˈstriːm/
Compound words which function as verbs and have an adverbial first element take final stress:	down'grade /daʊnˈgreɪd/ back-'pedal /bækˈped-əl/ under -ˈstand /ʌndə-ˈstænd/ over- ˈflow /əʊvə-ˈfləʊ/

Intonation

- **Intonation** is the way the voice rises or falls to create harmony among each words at the sentence level. To simplify, it is the music of speech. It focuses more on how we say it rather than what is being said. This is important in English communication because sentences may vary in meaning depending on the intonation. It also adds dimensions in our speech and makes it more compelling to hear.
- Common types and rules of Intonation:

1. Falling intonation (↓)
2. Rising intonation (↑)
3. Falling–rising intonation (↓ ↑)
4. Rising–falling intonation (↑ ↓)

Falling Intonation

This is when the pitch of the voice falls at the end of the sentence. It is commonly used in declarative sentences, commands, WH-questions questions, question tags and exclamatory sentences.

Statement	***Pleased to meet ↓you.*** ***Mom wants to buy that ↓bag.*** ***We should keep ↓going***
Commands	*Show me the way to the ↓station.* *Take your shoes ↓off.* *Leave them on the ↓desk.*
WH-questions	*What food do you ↓want?* *Where do you come ↓from?* *Whose book is ↓this?*
Question tags (confirming information/seeking agreement)	*He thinks he's so smart, doesn't ↓he?* *They didn't enjoy the party, did ↓they?* *She's the one you told me about, isn't ↓she?*
Exclamations	That's a perfect ↓gift! How nice of ↓you! What a beautiful ↓performance!

Rising intonation

- This is when the pitch of the voice rises at the end of the sentence. It is commonly used in yes or no questions, and question tags that show uncertainty.

Question tags (genuine question/verifying the truth)	***You're new here, aren't ↑you?*** ***He prefers the beach, doesn't ↑he?*** ***The rules were changed, weren't ↑they?***
Yes or No questions	*Do you like your new ↑shirt?* *May I borrow your ↑book?* *Will she ↑agree?*

Rising-Falling Intonation

- We do not only use rising or falling intonations alone, but we can likewise use a combination of both. Consider the rules of rising-falling intonation. This is generally used for giving out a list, a set of choices, partial and conditional statements.

Stating a list	***She bought some ↑bread, ↑flower, ↑pasta, and ↓apples.*** ***He enjoys outdoor activities such as ↑mountain climbing, ↑trekking, and ↓camping.*** ***This bag comes in colors of ↑white, ↑gray, ↑black, and ↓yellow***
Choices	*Would you like to have ↑tea or ↓coffee?* *Is Jay coming ↑today or ↓tomorrow?* *Did you say ↑east or ↓west?*
Partial statements	*What was the place like? –Well, it ↑seemed ↓nice… (but it's too small.)* *So did you enjoy the trip? –Hmmm, ↑yes I ↓did… (but it was too short.)*
Conditional statements	*If you have any ↑questions, send me a ↓message.* *Ever since you came ↑here, everything's doing ↓well.* *Unless she ↑asks, I'll stay ↓silent.*

Falling-rising intonation

- This is often used when the speaker is uncertain of an answer to a question or shows reluctance.
- For example:
- Should we ↓re↑port this incident?
- Do you think it is ↓va↑lid?
- Would he ↓su↑pport the team?

Articulation Drill

List of tongue twisters:

- She sells seashells by the seashore.
- I scream, you scream, we all scream for an Ice Cream.
- I saw a kitten eating chicken in the kitchen.
- I saw Susie sitting in a shoeshine shop.
- The thirty-three thieves thought that they thrilled the throne throughout Thursday.

Classroom Activity

Activity 1: Mark intonation according to the nature of sentence.
1. She is going to the store.
2. Are you coming to the party?
3. What time does the movie start?
4. What a beautiful day!
5. I bought apples, bananas and oranges from the supermarket.
6. You're coming to the meeting, aren't you?
7. If you had studied harder, you would have passed the test.
8. Are you planning to attend the meeting tomorrow or are you going to skip it?
9. If I go to the store, do you want me to pick anything or should I just leave?
10. Should we stay home and watch a movie or do you really want to go out tonight?

Activity 2: Mark accent on the following words.
1. Postgraduate
2. Owl
3. Import (noun) vs Import (verb)
4. Account (adjective) vs Account (verb)
5. Balance (adjective) vs Balance (verb)
6. Automatic
7. Mechanical
8. Nationalisation
9. Blackboard
10. Overcome

References

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